

Philosophy of Leadership Styles

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03/15/2006

Name	Version Date	Description
Jim Pham (Author)	3/13/2006	My personal philosophy of leadership styles
Jo Rainie Rodgers (Reviewer)	3/13/2006	Comment: You're a leader!
Joe McLaughlin (Reviewer)	3/13/2006	Comment: Very good personal reflection
Hans Peeters (Reviewer)	3/13/2006	Comment: Excellent! Nice integration of theory

A personal philosophy of leadership styles is a critical element of a leader's approach in leading, managing, and guiding people along the path of a shared vision. Behind every leader is a set of related beliefs in the philosophy of education and in theory-into-practice that influence how and what he/she will lead. A philosophy of leadership provides answers to questions about the leader's role, how he/she leads, and the methods used. Hence, there are many practice theories, but my leadership style is closely aligned with Behavioral, Contingency, and Situational theories. I know that a successful leader need not be limited to these theories alone but should embrace other scientific management theories and practices, and that no single style is better or more effective.

Presently, I serve as a collaborator, engineer, manager, and teacher. Yet, I am a leader. My leadership styles include organizational structure and management, team building, decision-making, problem-solving, and conflict management. Recognizing that each perspective has its strengths and weaknesses, I advocate for an eclectic approach to uncover best practices. Like any other personal development skill, leadership is an ongoing process that improves with practice and experience. In any situation, my leadership style is concerned not only with personal beliefs but also with personal preferences and impersonal environmental forces. In addition, I am mindful of ethical considerations, including fairness, equality, and inequality. As such, it is also circumstantial and depends on the situation and its contingent conditions. Its practice will also change and adapt over time. My idea of a great leader is one who inspires others, not just one who leads. A certain amount of creativity, enthusiasm, and motivation is required of the leader. Certainly, this is a tall order for anyone in a

profession on a daily basis. However, leaders are both visionaries and managers. I believe s/he possesses the power to make a difference, and his/her leadership style can impact people's lives for the better or worse.

My leadership experience thus far has been mainly in the computer industry. I am influenced by business practices, market trends, and current economic conditions, such as overseas job outsourcing, the dotcom bust, restructuring, and corporate downsizing. I have seen many companies rise to their peaks and fall. The rise and fall of the business cycle allows only the strongest companies to survive. Rapid advances in information technology, customer demands, globalization of the world's economies, and industrial restructuring have led to continuous technological change. Such dynamics have also forced considerable changes in organizational structure, divisions, groups, teams, and individuals. These changes (cause and effect) are not only affecting organizations but also inherently leaving people caught in unavoidable chaos, confusion, and frustration. At the same time, companies seek to achieve a sustainable future by restructuring, cutting costs, and embracing new business models. I believe that a company will succeed when it makes the right adjustments to its organizational structure. A successful leader will also need to retain enough qualified employees to help the company succeed.

Unlike businesses, college organizations are governed by a board of trustees and college administrators yet still face similar restructuring problems. In many ways, business practices force the transformation of colleges, their structures, and management styles. I understand that there is much opposition to business management styles, and I do think that these management styles are already being adopted by schools, whether we like it or not. From my industrial experience, I see that future colleges need to adopt

business-like practices. It is really about survival, stability, efficiency, and accountability. Colleges also need to harness the creative energies of their workforce. I believe that the future of the college lies in its people—administrators, faculty, students, and staff. The board of trustees also needs to be open to change.

I have also seen conflicts between management, employees, and people-to-people. Employees blame management for a lack of direction, poor internal communication, unclear structure, and an uncertain future, pointing fingers in all directions. Often, it is not management but people who get disenchanted and just simply leave the organization. Generally speaking, people like to feel needed and valuable. Through my experience, I have learned the importance of teamwork, which is fundamental to the overall management framework. Teamwork is formed at every structural level within the organization, including the management team and small groups. It encourages an open exchange of ideas and generates integrated, whole-systems solutions. More importantly, it strengthens the overall organizational structure and helps achieve shared vision, mission, and goals, as well as improved communication. At all structural levels, people need to feel part of the same team rather than a cog in a lifeless bureaucratic machine. Everyone is valued in building a shared-vision, and their work is meaningful. I believe that is an essential part of building a successful organization. It mobilizes energy and creates real enthusiasm in people. A tight coupling of the team network not only improves communication and collaboration between teams and their contributors. The more cohesive the group/team, the less conflict there is. Even though cohesive groups working together are much more effective, they can also be a source of conflict, such as a us-versus-them situation. These experiences have shaped my leadership style.

Also, my leadership style is grounded in fundamental beliefs and values, including professionalism, attitude, ethics, character, knowledge, skills, and actions. The theories that best describe my leadership style are Behavioral, Contingency, and Situational. From a behavioral standpoint, I am particularly interested in both structure and relationships. Structure focuses on the leader instituting structures—task-oriented. Relationships focus on the development and maintenance of relationships—a process-oriented approach. I believe that environments, circumstances, and sometimes both combinations are special situations that need to be flexible enough to adjust. A leader must be willing to alter the task and change the work process. Contingency theory is very similar to behavioral theory in which a leader needs to be flexible. Different leadership styles will be used at different times, suggesting that leadership is not a fixed set of characteristics but something that can be adapted to different contexts. Situational theory is more about managing people, such as directing, coaching, supporting, and delegating. My approach may also relate to other theories, such as Open Systems theory, Closed Systems theory, Complexity theory, and Transformational theory. In many ways, certain adaptations depend on the type of situation or circumstance.

Along with social beliefs about personal behavior, a leader ought to actively practice leadership in their own social life. I have five different leadership development areas—own life, family, workplace, community, and school. They are in this sequential order. A leader is well-educated and a contributing member of society. S/he possesses both breadth and depth of knowledge regarding competencies in certain disciplined areas. A successful leader is also a champion who demonstrates leadership ability in family, workplace, community, and school. This is behavioral leadership. This leadership skill

involves problem-solving, taking responsibility, helping others, and leading by example. Typically, people want to be guided by those they respect and have a clear sense of direction.

All leaders have different leadership styles, and no one style is better or more effective. My leadership styles are summarized in five focus areas: organizations empower people; people power organization; leader—power with people; manager—positional over people; and teamwork. My leadership styles can be summarized as follows:

Leadership Style

Leader

- Create a shared vision
- Understand the cultural/gender differences
- Communicate with meaning
- Maintaining ethics and trust
- Team building

Manager

- Directs/oversee people or processes
- Handles day-to-day functions
- Most concerned with efficiency
- The “how” structure
- Team building

Team Building Style

- Encourage team members to recognize each other’s accomplishments
- Establish a sense of urgency and High-Performance standards
- Encourage honest criticism
- Help team members
- Trust team members

Decision-Making Style

- Determine facts
- Decision Analysis
- Risk Analysis
- Decide the appropriate course of action

Conflict Management Style

- Keep conflict de-personalized
- Develop win-win solutions
- Develop shared objectives
- Value the different interests and points of view of all people

Problem-Solving Style

- Analytical, methodical, practical
- Objective and rational
- Establishes and follows plans
- Relies on fair policies and procedures

Believe in People

- Clearly defined goals
- Empowerment
- Open access to information
- Shared vision
- Training
- Trust

In addition, I believe that a personal leadership philosophy is critical for every successful leader. It serves as his/her touchstone for applying the skills and knowledge to their leadership role. Over time, s/he should review and reflect upon his/her philosophy as s/he integrates new experiences into his/her leadership role. I believe that leadership styles will also evolve over time, depending on situations, circumstances, and changes in the environment. Some leaders are naturally born, some are trained, and some are just at the right place at the right time. Regardless of their background, the leader must adapt to change and continuously improve. In closing thoughts, I'll end with this quote: "***If we're going to lead, we must set a direction and go there.***" -Lou Gerstner (1999)

References

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